

In response to the referral from Agriculture Senior Officials, the Animal Welfare Task Group (AWTG) is examining the use of virtual fencing technology - GPS-enabled neckband or collar devices worn by livestock producing electric pulses to deter animals from approaching or crossing a virtual fence boundary. An AWTG subgroup is examining animal welfare issues associated with virtual fencing technology, with a view to harmonising the approach to the use of this technology across jurisdictions.

The AWTG virtual fencing project is focused on supporting a harmonised approach to promoting optimal animal welfare outcomes, regardless of the type of virtual fencing product or where it is used.

Current progress

In 2024, AWTG agreed to develop an Australian Animal Welfare Guide for Virtual Fencing as the preferred approach for harmonisation, with the assistance of the Commonwealth as the project manager. The guide is currently with the AWTG, which is working towards finalisation by the end of 2025.

Purpose of the guide

States and territories regulate the use of virtual fencing. However, as virtual fencing technology is rapidly evolving and jurisdictions currently have differing regulatory baselines, it was agreed that a guide is the preferred approach for harmonisation as it can be developed relatively quickly and allows flexibility.

The guide will promote optimal animal welfare outcomes with the use of virtual fencing technology and its applications, for beef and dairy cattle, based on current science and evidence. It will not capture its use for other animal species but will acknowledge that technological developments and animal welfare research on this topic is ongoing.

The development process will differ from a standards and guidelines development process and the product delivered at completion will also be different. States and territories will be able to use the guide content as they see fit in their individual legislation and regulatory frameworks. The guide is not intended to provide recommendations on whether individual states and territories should support or oppose the use of virtual fencing technology.

As the guide will not contain recommendations for regulations, or recommend regulatory decisions, the guide will not undergo regulation impact analysis or public consultation. States and territories may consider further steps if they intend to make regulatory changes.

For further information on the commercial use of virtual fencing technology in each jurisdiction, refer to [State and Territory Government Animal Welfare Links and Legislation](#) to contact your relevant state or territory.

Scientific literature review

In February 2022, the subgroup identified the need to conduct an independent scientific literature review on animal welfare considerations for virtual fencing for livestock, which is now completed. The guide will be underpinned by this scientific literature review.

View a copy of the finalised literature review:

Independent scientific literature review on animal welfare considerations for virtual fencing

Virtual fencing technology and the legislation governing its use across jurisdictions continue to evolve. In recognition of this, the independent scientific literature review has an accompanying addendum which captures new, additional, and more detailed information on virtual fencing technology since the finalisation of the literature review. Information contained within the addendum does not form part of the literature review itself but will be considered by the subgroup.

View a copy of the addendum:

Addendum

- [Addendum – additional information provided by Halter \(PDF 209 KB\)](#)
- [Addendum – additional information provided by Halter \(DOCX 30.4 KB\)](#)

If you have difficulty accessing these files, [contact us](#) for help.

Stakeholder Reference Group

In April 2024, the subgroup established a Stakeholder Reference Group (SRG) to inform work to support harmonisation. Membership of the SRG consists of agricultural and animal welfare scientists and representatives from agricultural industry groups, animal welfare organisations and the veterinary industry from across Australia, with one representative from New Zealand. A series of meetings of the SRG were convened in mid-2024 and have now concluded. The guide will be developed considering input provided by the SRG.

View a copy of the SRG Terms of Reference:

Contacting the AWTG

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